north-west of the country, which was lion, rather than tiger, country. We know that there were important hunting grounds near Agra, Delhi, and Bhatinda in Punjab. Most of these areas are now densely populated and intensively farmed but Bernier tells us that there were large expanses of uncultivated land near Delhi and Agra as well as on the road to Lahore. It is estimated that barely 27.5 per cent of Agra suba, at the heart of the empire, was cultivated in 1600. [29] The human population of India at that time was around 116 million. This means that there were large areas that were available to wildlife and several tracts were reserved exclusively for the royal hunt. The association of the lion with the power of the State remained. The hunting of lions was reserved for the king and the royal family and was closed to others, except by special permission.

There are many stories about Emperor Akbar's lion hunts. On one occasion in 1568, Akbar went hunting in the Mewat region near Alwar, south of Gurgaon. A lion emerged and was quickly slain by a hail of arrows shot by his companions. Akbar was annoyed and ordered that should another lion emerge, he would tackle it himself. At that very moment, another lion did emerge and the emperor shot it in the eye with an arrow. The enraged animal charged but Akbar could not get a good shot even though he had dismounted from his horse. In the excitement of the moment, one of the courtiers shot an arrow that infuriated the lion who mauled the man. The animal had to be finished off by other courtiers. [30]

As one can see, Akbar was quite ready to take personal risks and, in his younger days, would hunt on horseback or even on foot. His main indulgence was the use of a large number of trained cheetahs to help him in the chase. Later in life he would keep a stable of a thousand of these beasts. Over time, however, the emperors grew used to hunting from the relative safety of an elephant's back and to the use of increasingly accurate guns. In a single hunting expedition to Rupbas near Agra in February–March 1610, Akbar's successor, Jehangir, and his companions killed seven lions, seventy Nilgai, fifty-one blackbuck, eighty-two other animals, 129 birds and 1023